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GENDER

Women's College Infirmary Charges Five Rupees Per Pad; Automatic Dispensers Charge Ten

At Kalindi College — a Delhi University institution that calls itself all-women's and teaches courses in feminist theory — the medical infirmary charges students five rupees per sanitary pad. A ground report on the gap between institutional pride and the institutional care actually on offer.

BY MOULI SHARMA

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I was so happy I thought I'd finally get something, anything, even just a Crocin, some damn electrolytes, whatever they'd give me, at that point, I'd be grateful. But turns out it was just someone from the cleaning staff who'd noticed the door was open. She came in & started interrogating me, chastising me for presuming to let myself in, implying I may have vandalised the room & god knows what else. She stayed till the nurse arrived, which was another 15 minutes later, but she made it very clear it wasn't out of any real concern for my well-being, just 'keeping watch'. By the time the nurse arrived, I was already sufficiently distracted from the fever by the third degree. She silently watched as the woman berated me for another long while, not just condoning but appreciating what had happened before finally asking me what was wrong. She gave me a small paracetamol tablet & made me sign in the register. I've never gone to the medical room since." The authorities' description of the room & its capabilities make it clear that they do not exceed beyond being able to provide extremely elementary medical aid to students for their, in their own words, 'minor inconveniences.' So, the refusal of medical staff to then entertain & treat what inconveniences they do deem as minor, beg the question what purpose, if any, this facility serves at all. Accounts like the ones above are

Excessive control & a resource-precious attitude make Kalindi College's medical infirmary functionally redundant.

February 25, 2023, New Delhi: On 8 March 1914, the arrest of Sylvia Pankhurst was the domino that tipped the way to the celebration of International Women's Day today. Over a century later, things are little more than marginally better, and the consolation we get is that at least they're 'changing.' And slowly but surely, it seems they are. Urban women's lives have lost all identifiable traces of the barbaric pasts that unfortunately still cling to many. Yet there are some fundamental structures of our society, the very institutions that were meant to be the flag bearers of this change - lead the way, so to speak - that are perhaps holding it back.

In Delhi University's Kalindi College, one that takes great pride in calling itself an all-women's institution (one that boasts of being one of what are DU's handful of institutions that have a media department, & in it countless courses has countless readings on gender, society & feminist theory), an individual sanitary napkin at the already ill-equipped & resource-fond infirmary incurs students a cost of a loud, dumbfounding 5 rupees.

Decisions like these are what make the Pink Tax so pervasive & inescapable in modern societal structures. The average ranges of Whisper & Stayfree napkins, two of India's most popular brands & also the most commonly stocked in colleges like Kalindi, are priced at rupees Rs. 26-29 for the one-week packs, i.e. Rs. 4 per pad. Charging students a single rupee more, therefore neither subsidises this cost for them nor makes any significant contribution towards recovering let alone profiting off of it. The only purpose it serves, is to discourage students from using a facility that is meant to be for them.

A 'Well-Equipped' Room: Shell Facilities in Government Institutes

"My friend was on her period the other day, and so I'd gone to grab her a pad from the infirmary. I was charged 5 rupees for the napkin. The incident was stupefying in a way. It is not just about the amount you have to pay but the fact that you have to pay at all," says Shruti Patel, a senior at Kalindi & Head of Design at TVE. "You don't expect there to be a fee on a pad in a college 'medical room.'"

"It's degrading," added another student.

Interestingly, this resource-precious attitude is not limited to sanitary napkins, but extends to the entire facility of what Kalindi College's website describes as a 'well-equipped medical room [where] the college provides good medical facility to students & staff.' Students are forced to purchase basic first aid items like band-aids & gauze from pharmacies outside the campus or exaggerate difficulties to be provided any help at the infirmary.

"I remember my ankles being scraped raw the day of our NCC fest. I went to the medical room hoping to get some gauze or anything for relief, but all they gave me was one band-aid. The nurse said she wouldn't give me even a second one unless I showed her blood," says Manasvi Vats, the JUO of Udaan, Kalindi College's NCC. Manasvi tells us she had to call up her friend to bring her band-aids from home instead. They cost 2 rupees.

Dr. Rajshree Lal of the medical staff remains available for attending students and staff for their 'minor complaints' for three hours every alternate day of the week. The remaining time, the room is under the management of Ms. Rekha, who visits the college every day from 9 AM to 5 PM. Most students know the medical room as synonymous with nurse Rekha, a smiling, kind-faced woman who would rather the cleaning staff do her dirty work for her, both literally & otherwise, as the following account from a senior who would rather remain anonymous describes.

"I remember having a fever of around 100 one time back in my first year. I somehow managed to drag myself to the medical room in between classes - & this was nearly noon, so the heat was severe - & it was closed. The door was bolted. I looked around, I tried to ask people, but there was no one & I was doing so poorly that eventually, I couldn't wait anymore. I thought I'd at least get inside, and sit down; I was on the verge of passing out. So I unbolted the door & sat down & there was so much immediate relief, getting off my feet & out of the heat.

I must have waited for - what, at least another 15 minutes, before anyone came. I was so happy I thought I'd finally get something, anything, even just a Crocin, some damn electrolytes, whatever they'd give me, at that point, I'd be grateful. But turns out it was just someone from the cleaning staff who'd noticed the door was open. She came in & started interrogating me, chastising me for presuming to let myself in, implying I may have vandalised the room & god knows what else. She stayed till the nurse arrived, which was another 15 minutes later, but she made it very clear it wasn't out of any real concern for my well-being, just 'keeping watch'. By the time the nurse arrived, I was already sufficiently distracted from the fever by the third degree. She silently watched as the woman berated me for another long while, not just condoning but appreciating what had happened before finally asking me what was wrong. She gave me a small paracetamol tablet & made me sign in the register. I've never gone to the medical room since."

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"We used to train (march) out in the parking lot during the summers & students would pass out or come close on a near daily basis. If you bring another student to speak for you, the nurse reluctantly gives you glucose or something, because they can exaggerate the issue. If you are, say, dehydrated to the point of blacking out, you can get a glass of glucose," said a senior of Udaan. This is especially egregious in the face of the faculty's revelation that the only qualified

This article was pitched by Shruti Patel. Head of Design at TVE, Shruti is a beginner in the design field. She likes to work with illustrations, ux design and packaging, & (this part is not written by her) her eye is incomperable. She also writes sometimes.

Conflict of Interest statement: this article is about Kalindi College, Delhi University, which is where TVE was founded in 2022.

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Mouli Sharma is a journalist, freelance illustrator, and writer from New Delhi, India. She is a published photojournalist & illustrator, having been featured in The Hindu College Gazette, & the quarterly Pink Disco. Mouli took over as the Editor of The Voice Express (<https://thevoiceexpress.github.io/e-mag/>) back in September 2023.

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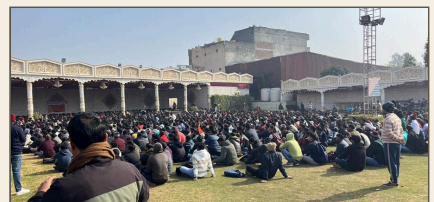
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